

MINDFULNESS HANDOUT 1A

Mindfulness Definitions

WHAT IS MINDFULNESS?

- **Intentionally living with awareness in the present moment.**
(Waking up from automatic or rote behaviors to participate and be present to our own lives.)
- **Without judging or rejecting the moment.**
(Noticing consequences, discerning helpfulness and harmfulness—but letting go of evaluating, avoiding, suppressing, or blocking the present moment.)
- **Without attachment to the moment.**
(Attending to the experience of each new moment, rather than ignoring the present by clinging to the past or grabbing for the future.)

WHAT ARE MINDFULNESS SKILLS?

- Mindfulness skills are the specific behaviors to practice that, when put together, make up mindfulness.

WHAT IS MINDFULNESS PRACTICE?

- **Mindfulness and mindfulness skills** can be practiced at any time, anywhere, while doing anything. Intentionally paying attention to the moment, without judging it or holding on to it, is all that is needed.
- **Meditation** is practicing mindfulness and mindfulness skills while sitting, standing, or lying quietly for a predetermined period of time. When meditating, we *focus* the mind (for example, we *focus* on body sensations, emotions, thoughts, or our breath), or we *open* the mind (paying attention to whatever comes into our awareness). There are many forms of meditation that differ mostly by whether we are opening the mind or focusing the mind—and, if focusing, depending on what is the focus of our attention.
- **Contemplative prayer** (such as Christian centering prayer, the rosary, Jewish Shema, Islamic Sufi practice, or Hindu raja yoga) is a spiritual mindfulness practice.
- **Mindfulness movement** also has many forms. Examples include yoga, martial arts (such as Qigong, tai chi, aikido, and karate), and spiritual dancing. Hiking, horseback riding, and walking can also be ways to practice mindfulness.